

The basic rules of an Oxford debate:

I. Introduction

The Oxford-style debate is used when difficult and controversial topics need to be discussed, whilst adhering to the principles of assertiveness and respect for the other side's views.

1. there are two sides:

A. the Proposition (supporting the motion)

B. the Opposition (disagreeing with the motion),

- each side presents arguments in a structured order,
- speakers must respect the time limits,
- participants should respond to arguments rather than criticize individuals,
- the audience listens actively, asks questions, and votes at the end.

2. The roles are also explained:

- **Moderator** – leads the debate and ensures the rules are respected,
- **Time manager** – controls the time given for each speaker
- **Speakers** – present arguments for or against the motion,
- **Audience/Jury** – listens, asks questions, and evaluates the debate.

II. Main Part — Educational Activities

Activity 1:

Participants are divided into groups and work together to prepare arguments either in favour of or against the debate motion.

Instructions:

- The moderator divides the participants into three groups:
 - A. supporters,**
 - B. opponents**
 - C. audience/jury.**
- Each side is tasked with preparing at least three key arguments to support their position.
- Participants are encouraged to draw on personal experiences, practical examples from everyday life, and social and civic perspectives.
- The audience group prepares 2–3 questions to ask both sides during the debate.
- To support the preparation process, the moderator may write key questions on the board.

Activity 2:

Objective: To develop communication, critical thinking, and argumentation skills through structured discussion.

Description: Participants take part in a moderated Oxford-style debate based on the prepared motion.

Instructions:

II. The course of the debate

1. Debates revolve around a specific motion, which is defended by **the Proposition** (the Affirmative side) and challenged by **the Opposition** (the Negative side). The motion should be clearly and unambiguously defined.

2. Structure of the debate:

The debate is always opened by the first speaker from the Affirmative side. Thereafter, speakers take turns

A. This signal is usually a raised hand. The first raise indicates 30 seconds remaining, the second raise indicates the end of speaking time.

B. The motion must not take the form of a question (Is a dog nice?) or a choice (dog or cat). The motion must advocate a specific position: (A dog is the best pet).

C. Speakers from each side take the floor (1st speaker P -> 1st speaker O -> 2nd speaker P -> 2nd speaker O etc.) The debate always concludes with the 4th speaker from the Opposition.

- Each speaker has a set time for their speech (up to 3 minutes),
 - Each speech must begin with a brief invocation addressed to the Chair, the opposing side and the audience (in exactly that order), e.g.: Mr Chair, Honourable Opponents, wonderful audience,
 - During their speech, each speaker must address at least two questions or points raised by the opposing side. The speaker indicates their intention to address a question or point by raising their hand.
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- The moderator ensures that all participants are treated respectfully, everyone has equal opportunity to speak, and the discussion remains focused on the topic.
 - At the end of the debate, the audience votes on which side presented the more convincing arguments.